

7/27 – Intro to Web Development and Marketing, Web Dev-Design I, Email Preferences Page Discussion

Intro to Web Development and Marketing

Speaker: Josh

Session Setup and Project Background

- The rotation opened with an overview of a website rebuild for Cohesion, a small events partner organization that runs a large conference many client colleges attend
- Cohesion had no internal resources and had been running on a default GoDaddy template with very limited customization, so Josh was assigned to rebrand the organization and rebuild its site
- A companion project introduced that day was an email subscription and unsubscribe page, letting contacts turn categories of marketing email on or off
- The immediate blocker on that page was that email selections were single flat lists, while Evisions needed sub-lists nested under broader categories to match its many products

WordPress Environment and Hosting

- Evisions hosts its WordPress sites on WP Engine, a managed WordPress host that is more expensive than typical hosts but includes backups and security handling
- WordPress runs on PHP as its backend language, which is not visible to the end user, while HTML, CSS, and JavaScript handle everything the browser renders
- The site uses a child theme built on top of the Divi parent theme, which allows customization without altering the core theme files, so updates to the parent theme do not overwrite custom work
- A new WordPress install was created live during the session, including the standard install script, database setup, and initial login

Choosing a Website Platform

- Carter noted that his own portfolio was built and deployed through GitHub Pages, using VS Code as the environment
- Josh explained that platform choice depends on who will maintain the site: a single owner has more freedom, while a site with multiple non-technical contributors benefits from a CMS like WordPress
- GitHub Pages serves static files with no built-in database, which makes it well suited to a personal portfolio but not to a site needing dynamic content or a shop
- WordPress is a strong fit for marketing-style sites with landing pages and email templates, but Josh cautioned against using it for a complex web application with heavy custom logic

Web Fundamentals Refresher

- Carter's background is primarily JavaScript and Node.js from coursework, along with C#, C++, and Python
- Josh introduced Flexbox and CSS Grid as the two main layout systems: Flexbox is easier to pick up and covers most responsive needs, while Grid offers more precise control for layouts that need to rearrange more deliberately across screen sizes
- Divi's own layout system is built on a Flexbox-style model, so comfort with Flexbox terminology carries over directly

Industry and Career Discussion

- Josh shared his own path into web development, starting with an early interest in art and website tinkering during the rise of social media, which eventually merged with a growing interest in technology
- Josh emphasized that a design or art background gives a developer an edge, since usability and visual polish are often what separate a tool that markets well from one that does not, using the older Argos interface versus the modernized Argos X as an example
- Recommended ways to explore web development further included picking a real but unpolished small business or nonprofit site and redesigning it as a self-directed project, since having an actual problem to solve is more motivating than a blank exercise
- CodePen was introduced as a resource for browsing other developers' front-end experiments, reverse-engineering effects such as animated hero sections, and building a lightweight public portfolio of small demos
- Notable portfolio examples referenced included scroll-driven, game-like resume sites, and Awwwards was mentioned as a site that showcases boundary-pushing web design work

AI and Industry Tangents

- Conversation touched on emerging AI agent tooling and autonomous agent platforms, including AI-only social networks where bot accounts interact with one another
- Broader industry discussion covered the tradeoffs of large AI data center buildouts, including job creation versus environmental cost and the risk to local jobs if a data center operator were to fail

Wrap and Next Steps

- Carter was given login access to the new WordPress environment to begin exploring the Divi editor independently
- The plan for the following day was to build out an AI-assisted email template for webinars in Pardot, which would require different conventions than plain WordPress editing

Web Dev-Design I

Speaker: Josh

Divi Builder Basics

- Pages in Divi are structured as sections containing rows, and rows containing columns, with modules placed inside those columns
- The design panel on each module or section exposes settings for background color, padding, margin, border radius, shadows, and similar visual attributes
- Divi's prebuilt layout library was shown as a starting point, letting a page be assembled quickly from a template and then have its content swapped out
- A right-click option to extend attributes across multiple elements at once was highlighted as a way to speed up repetitive styling work

Practice Build: Portfolio-Style Page

- Carter was walked through building a sample landing page section, including a heading text module, a paragraph module, and button modules, as a way to get comfortable with the editor
- Josh built the top section live as a demonstration, then handed the page to Carter to continue independently and get familiar with the tool at his own pace
- The stated goal was not a polished result, but comfort navigating sections, rows, columns,

and the design panel

Internal Tools Built by Josh

- A brand hub site was demonstrated, centralizing logos, brand colors, PowerPoint templates, product messaging talking points, and design resources for company-wide use
- Design resources included Undraw for customizable illustration assets and Font Awesome for an icon font library that can be linked into a site
- A custom WordPress plugin, the eVisions video hub, was shown, which creates a custom post type for videos, imports them from YouTube and Wistia by API, and lets a page filter and tag videos by topic; the plugin was originally built with Claude
- A pre-filtered version of the same tool powers the Argos X Academy page, showing only that product's training videos
- An internal events hub tool was also demonstrated, giving each salesperson assigned to a conference a single place to view schedule, travel, and flight information for that event, replacing a page that had been buried in Confluence
- Josh noted these internal tools were built to solve specific, recognized pain points rather than as speculative projects

WordPress Plugin Ecosystem

- WordPress has a large plugin ecosystem covering nearly any added functionality, including WooCommerce for shop functionality, ACF (Advanced Custom Fields) for dynamic content, and Yoast for SEO
- Josh's general approach is to keep as much functionality in-house as possible, since installing a plugin creates a dependency on that plugin's developer continuing to maintain and update it
- Smaller, niche plugins carry more risk of going unmaintained, which can create security exposure as WordPress core continues to update

AI Tools in Practice

- Josh described using Claude heavily for self-contained tools built from plain HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, often backed by a JSON file instead of a full database when the tool does not need one
- Claude was also used to help design a personal resume as a styled HTML document
- Josh's stated next step in his own AI use is building more automated, scheduled agent workflows, using as an example the manual process of downloading a GoToMeeting webinar recording and re-uploading it to Wistia, which he would like to automate end to end

Career and Advice Discussion

- Recommended starter projects included redesigning a real local business or nonprofit site, since having an actual audience and problem produces a stronger portfolio piece than a generic exercise
- Josh noted that corporate web development, especially on the marketing side, tends toward landing pages and email templates rather than full application development, and suggested Carter weigh that against interest in web application development specifically
- Josh's own career path at Evisions moved from support, into marketing (graphic design and email templates), into an operations role building internal tooling, and back into marketing after that operations team was dissolved
- Many employees across departments, including engineering and professional services, started in support and transferred internally over time, illustrating that an entry-level role is not

necessarily a fixed path

- Discussion touched on the Huntsville job market being difficult to break into directly out of school due to the concentration of defense contractors requiring both years of experience and security clearance
- General networking advice included using LinkedIn connections from any professional encounter, and being open to a non-ideal first role as a way to get into a company with room to move departments later

Email Preferences Page Discussion

Speakers: Jake Taft (Head of Marketing), Josh, Ann Sanchez

The Core Technical Problem

- Pardot, the marketing automation platform built on Salesforce, only supports flat email lists, with no native concept of parent and child list relationships
- To support granular preferences across many products, the team needs to build a structure of dynamic lists synced from the preference center page, rather than one master list per category
- Once the framework for one category is built and tested, the same pattern should be repeatable for the remaining categories

Consent Model: Opt-In vs. Opt-Out

- The team decided against exposing every individual product sub-list to the contact directly, to avoid choice overload and to avoid making a contact feel exposed about which lists they belong to
- The agreed model puts the friction on the internal side: a contact simply opts in or out of a broad category, such as webinars, and internally that gets crossed against which product audiences that contact already belongs to
- The baseline behavior at launch is that existing contacts are opted into current categories by default, with the preference center offered as a place to actively opt out

Defining the Preference Categories

- **Newsletter** – straightforward, single list, kept largely as is
- **Product updates** – a contact opts into the category as a whole, and internally is cross-referenced against which specific product audiences they belong to before being included in a given send
- **Community learning** – covers general tips, how-tos, and educational content not tied to a single product; the group agreed it did not need to be product specific and could launch as one list
- **Webinars and events** – kept as its own category, separate from general marketing, since it behaves differently and is tied to specific dated activities
- **Training** – discussed as a category tied to the Argos X Academy video library, which was already close to launch
- A generic marketing announcements category (new product or page launches not already covered elsewhere) was discussed and folded into the other categories for simplicity rather than kept as its own line item

Argos X Academy Context

- The Argos X Academy was introduced as a response to two adoption problems: making customers aware that upgrading from the original Argos to Argos X is available and easy, and giving customers a way to learn the new platform once upgraded

- Short how-to videos are being recorded and hosted in this academy so customers have a self-service way to ramp up on the new platform

Next Steps

- Final categories agreed on for the initial rollout: newsletter, product updates, community learning, and webinars and events
- Maya was tasked with reviewing the last two months of sent emails to confirm every send cleanly maps into one of the four categories, and to flag anything that does not

7/28 – Create Email Template, Marketing & Sales Weekly Tactical Meeting, Web Dev-Design II

Create Email Template

Speaker: Josh

Building a Multi-Webinar Pardot Template

- The task was to build a Pardot email template for a series of webinars, derived from an existing solo-webinar template but restructured to be modular
- Josh used Claude to generate the HTML and CSS quickly, working from the existing template as a style and structure reference rather than starting from a blank page
- Pardot requires specific markup conventions, sometimes referred to informally as tags or class call-outs, so that sections of a template register as editable or removable inside the Pardot editor; this is what lets a non-developer end user, such as Maya, edit or remove content blocks without touching code
- Because a reference template already existed, this build went through fewer iterations than usual before it was ready

Email Rendering Across Clients

- Email templates have to be coded for multiple rendering engines at once, since older Outlook versions render HTML email using Microsoft Word's rendering engine rather than a standard browser engine, while Gmail and newer Outlook use closer to normal HTML and CSS
- Client-specific quirks, such as how buttons render in Outlook (smaller sizing, missing rounded corners), have to be accounted for directly in the code
- AI-assisted generation was noted as making it considerably easier to account for all three rendering environments at once, compared to the earlier manual process of building for one client and then fixing breakage in another

Testing and Quality Control

- Every new template gets a test send before being handed off, including a check of the plain-text-only version alongside the HTML version
- Josh cited a past incident where the text-only version of a template drifted out of sync with the HTML version and referenced a product Evisions no longer sold, so syncing the two versions before every send is now a standard check

Marketing Tool Stack and Selection Process

- Evisions previously used a different CRM alongside HubSpot before consolidating onto Salesforce, largely because the sales team was already standardized on Salesforce
- Pardot came bundled with Salesforce as part of that transition, but several features that existed natively in HubSpot, such as automatic blog subscription emails through RSS, do

not exist natively in Pardot and have to be recreated manually through a connector tool like Zapier

- Team members can choose their own tools for work fully internal to their department, but a tool touching multiple departments, such as a CRM or marketing automation platform, goes through a broader evaluation and decision process, often led by an operations VP
- Migrating marketing platforms is a heavy lift, since it requires migrating historical data and relearning workflows, which is part of why the team is reluctant to switch tools again after having done so multiple times
- Asana is currently used for project management, though a large share of day-to-day task tracking still happens informally through Slack

AI Video and Landing Page Projects

- Josh demonstrated Pangram, an AI video generation tool that can incorporate a company's own images and existing recorded footage rather than generating fully synthetic scenes, used to prototype a low-cost product teaser video
- Pricing was noted as a real constraint: a mid-tier Pangram plan runs about 60 dollars a month for roughly 4,000 credits, and a single 60-second video with edits can consume 700 to 1,200 credits, limiting output to a few videos per month without buying more credits
- A targeted landing page project was described, which scrapes a prospect college's own website for statistics and facts, then combines that with internal product information to generate a custom landing page addressed to that specific institution
- Because generating landing pages for roughly 40 to 50 schools burned through Claude usage limits quickly, Josh split the workflow: bulk page generation ran through ChatGPT, and Claude was then used afterward to audit the ChatGPT output for mistakes
- The project expanded from a narrower goal of encouraging Argos X upgrades into a broader tool for reaching prospects who do not yet own any Evisions product, including a section recommending similar case studies based on a school's size and type

Marketing & Sales Weekly Tactical Meeting

Speakers: Jen, Brian, Jared, Jim, interns

Meeting Purpose

- This is a recurring weekly touchpoint aligning marketing and sales, typically run by Jen, Brian, Jim, and Jared, reviewing the past week and discussing what each side can do to generate more leads and opportunities
- Interns from several different shadowing tracks were invited to this particular session since sales and marketing intersects with what each of them was observing that week

Sales Forecast Review

- Jen walked through current quarter booking percentages by product line, noting deals in contract negotiation and a large opportunity that was intentionally left out of the committed forecast until further along
- Momentum on Argos-related deals was tied directly to the new Dashboard Designer and Data Agent capabilities, described as giving reps something tangible and modern to show schools that had previously written the platform off as outdated
- A prospecting push was underway targeting Argos and Colleague customers who do not yet own FormFusion, using a customer list pulled from Scout and cross-referenced against customer success for account health context

Lead Follow-Up Discipline

- A recent webinar generated a large batch of high-intent hand-raisers, and leadership pushed for a consistent, disciplined follow-up cadence rather than letting leads go cold
- The recommended cadence pattern was call, email, call, email spaced out over several weeks, with leads that go cold rolled back into a longer-term nurture track instead of being dropped
- Reps were asked to verify follow-up tasks were actually scheduled and being worked, since an internal audit had found the pipeline was not as current as expected
- A new prioritization matrix was introduced for high-intent leads generated from a webinar, ranking contacts from tier one (executive and C-suite) down to tier five (analyst and individual contributor) based on job role, so reps know who to reach first
- The team discussed whether prospects who registered but did not raise their hand should still receive a lighter-touch nurture campaign rather than no follow-up at all, particularly if their role is senior

Marketing Tool Evaluation: Artisan

- The team discussed whether to continue paying for Artisan, an AI outreach tool being trialed at roughly 27,000 dollars a year, weighing its cost against whether it was clearly driving pipeline beyond what reps were already generating through Salesloft
- Rather than committing further budget immediately, the decision was to ask the vendor for an extended trial through the end of the year at no additional cost, or to treat that request as an effective notice of non-renewal if declined

Email Cadence and Channel Strategy

- The team discussed consolidating some touchpoints, such as webinar promotion emails, into a lighter digest format instead of sending separate dedicated emails for every event
- Paid advertising on LinkedIn targeted at specific titles and institutions was raised as a possible more efficient channel than broad Google ad spend, alongside product-specific webinars aimed at Colleague customers

Sales Process Changes

- Salesloft, previously used by the sales team to run its own outbound email campaigns, was flagged as being used inconsistently and contributing to over-emailing the same contacts
- A working session between marketing and the sales reps themselves was planned to build a shared lead-generation and follow-up plan, so reps are bought into the process rather than simply being told to follow up more

Intern Q&A

- Interns were invited to ask about any terms or concepts used quickly during the meeting; one term clarified for the group was “delta,” referring to the difference or gap between two values
- Leadership tied the discussion back to the broader theme of the meeting: solving the urgency of qualifying leads quickly enough to hit forecasted goals for each product line

Web Dev-Design II

Speaker: Josh

Building Toward a Portfolio Site

- Josh proposed that Carter build a proper online portfolio site in Divi, rather than relying solely on the GitHub-based portfolio, and pull in work already documented on GitHub
- The plan was to work on it together as a starting point, with Carter then making his own design choices from there

Divi Editor Limitations

- Carter noted difficulty with freeform placement of elements inside Divi compared to a tool like Canva, since Divi modules are self-contained within their column and cannot be freely dragged anywhere on the page without manual X/Y transform values or a custom code module
- Josh explained the underlying structure again to work around this: setting a background color at the column level rather than the module level, so multiple modules can sit visually together inside one styled container

Styling a Countdown Module

- Carter had built a countdown module for a conference registration section, and the two worked through refining its styling together, including background color, border radius, padding, and reducing font size on the number elements
- Right-click "extend attributes" was used again as a shortcut to apply the same styling choices across repeated elements at once, rather than repeating each change manually
- Background masks and layered color options at the section and column level were used to move away from Divi's default circular background pattern toward a custom look

Wireframing and AI-Assisted Design Tools

- Josh mentioned using Miro previously for wireframing and found it easier for mapping out ideas than doing so directly inside Divi
- Divi's paid AI extension was discussed; Josh had tried it roughly two and a half years earlier for content generation and found it limited at the time, though he acknowledged it may have improved significantly since

Session Notes

- The session was interrupted several times by outside circumstances, and the pair wrapped early after confirming the schedule for the following day, which included a marketing meeting

7/29 – Marketing Meeting, Wrap-up

Marketing Meeting

Speakers: Jim, Josh, Maya, Cassidy (Cass), Shelley (referenced)

Defining a Marketing Qualified Lead

- Some organizations define a marketing qualified lead (MQL) purely by an automated lead score built from website visits, webinar attendance, and similar signals inside a marketing automation platform
- Evisions defines an MQL more narrowly: a contact who explicitly requests more information about a specific solution through a marketing campaign or event, which the team is comfortable handing directly to sales

Lead Assignment Automation

- The previous manual process for assigning sales tasks from a lead list required updating multiple fields on each individual Salesforce profile, which could take Maya several hours for a batch of a hundred leads
- A new automated workflow, built with help from Shelley, now generates a sales task automatically from status updates made at the campaign level, factoring in territory, product, and date, cutting Maya's manual time roughly in half
- The automation change broke the previous MQL reporting method, since that reporting relied

on a manually updated sales status field that is no longer being touched in the new workflow

- The proposed fix is a dedicated MQL checkbox field in Salesforce that gets set automatically regardless of lead source (webinar hand-raiser, event, or website form), giving a single reliable field to report from

Email Frequency and Overload

- The team identified that long-running nurture campaigns, product-specific outreach, and sales' own outbound campaigns were overlapping on the same contacts, in some cases resulting in twenty or more emails to a single contact since June
- A specific client complaint prompted the review: a customer said they did not want to unsubscribe entirely but felt the volume of email from Evisions was too high
- As a baseline example, a contact could receive four nurture emails, six emails from two webinars at three touches each, and a monthly newsletter, totaling eleven emails before sales outreach is even added
- The team agreed this reflects becoming a victim of their own success with lead generation, and that without changes, rising unsubscribe rates and falling open rates would eventually damage the health of the contact database

Consolidation and Preference Center Progress

- Cassidy has already begun consolidating webinar promotional emails into a combined digest format covering multiple upcoming webinars in one send, reserving dedicated three-touch promotion only for the highest-priority webinars
- Nurture email frequency was also adjusted to a biweekly or weekly cadence depending on the segment, with ongoing evaluation as it rolls out
- The preference center's next phase is building out dynamic, product-specific lists on the back end so that a contact who owns one product is not messaged about categories unrelated to their product, without exposing that complexity to the contact directly
- A separate marketing category, distinct from the nurture/sales-style track, was reinstated so a contact could opt out of nurture messaging while still receiving product updates, webinars, and event communications
- A plan was proposed to track opt-out volume by category over time (using a dynamic list of everyone who has opted out) as a way to learn which types of content the contact base values most

Sales-Side Email Changes

- Salesloft, which the sales team had been using for its own outbound cadences, is being turned off after devolving from targeted, scaled prospecting into high-volume blasting that was not being actively managed
- A meeting with the sales team was planned to discuss the shift and the alternative process going forward

Webinar and Argos X Academy Update

- The recent joint Dashboard Designer and Data Agent webinar produced more than 80 hand-raisers and over 100 individual contacts requesting Dashboard Designer, with new institutions activating the tool daily
- Roughly 70 percent of opportunities generated across marketing and sales that quarter were tied back to attendees of that single Data Agent webinar
- Josh demonstrated the new Argos X Academy page, built on the same video hub plugin shown earlier in the rotation, including searchable video browsing and a completion badge

shown once a viewer reaches 90 percent of a video

- The Academy’s purpose is to remove adoption friction: reducing the perceived difficulty of upgrading to Argos X and giving customers a self-service way to learn the new platform once upgraded
- Tracking is set up specifically on the Argos X Academy page so the team can see which institutions are actively engaging with those videos, since that activity is a strong signal for customer success outreach

Market Context: SLED and Higher Ed

- The SLED market (State, Local, and Education) was described as one of the slowest-moving technology markets, largely due to constrained budgets, limited IT resources, and complex legacy systems
- Evisions’ strategy in this market was described as protect and extend: preserving customers’ long-standing on-prem investments while gradually extending them toward cloud-based capabilities as institutions become ready
- The current wave of Data Agent and Dashboard Designer adoption is described as a rare moment of accelerated movement in an otherwise slow-moving market, partly because it also requires updated license agreements

EC27 Conference Planning

- The annual Evisions conference is tentatively planned around the same weekend as Ellucian Live each year, which in 2027 falls in New Orleans in early April
- Clients are already asking early budgeting questions about cost and dates for next year’s conference, even before a location or firm date has been announced
- A save-the-date style email with preliminary information was proposed as a way to get ahead of client budgeting cycles, since attendees often need approval from their own leadership well in advance

Wrap-up

Speaker: Josh

Rebranding the Conference Site

- The final session focused on reworking the existing conference microsite into a New Orleans-themed design for the next event, keeping much of the current page structure and content but changing the visual theme and animations
- Josh’s typical starting point for a themed design is sourcing vector art around the target theme, since vector graphics (SVGs on the web) scale without losing quality

Asset Sourcing Workflow

- Josh’s process involves downloading a relevant vector illustration file, then pulling individual elements out of it in Illustrator rather than using the graphic as a single flat image
- Once a clipping mask is released on a downloaded asset, individual elements inside it can be isolated, repositioned, and exported separately as SVGs for use on the site
- A stock imagery site with AI-generated people and scenes was noted as the source for most of the people imagery currently used across the Evisions site, which Josh then edits further in Photoshop

New Orleans Theme Concept

- The proposed concept followed the site’s vertical scroll structure with a progression of New Orleans imagery by section, opening in the French Quarter, moving into a Bourbon Street

and Mardi Gras themed section, and closing with a riverboat scene

- Mardi Gras-related visuals were suggested as background elements behind call-to-action sections rather than as literal icons

Animation Approach

- Custom CSS animations, such as the animated birds and clouds on the current conference site, are built with AI assistance to help work out the animation timing and motion, which previously could take significantly longer to hand-code

Mockup and Approval Process

- Rather than rebuilding the live site directly, Josh’s plan was to build a staging copy so the existing site’s rights and content remain intact while the new design is developed separately
- A static mockup or screenshot-based layout is typically shared first with stakeholders such as Cassidy to align on direction before any live build begins
- Josh described past instances where a fully developed concept, such as a race-car theme built around the Celebrator product for a Denver event, was ultimately scrapped in favor of a different direction at leadership’s request, underscoring that creative direction can change even after significant work is done

Working Style Reflection

- Josh described enjoying the ability to move between coding and more visual, creative design work, noting that seeing tangible visual results is part of what drew him toward front-end and design work specifically